AI and Society

0 Course Information

Instructor: Yifan Cai (caiyifan@cuhk.edu.cn)

1 Course Description

This course draws on perspectives and theories from Science and Technology Studies (STS) to examine the interplay between AI and society. It investigates how socio-political contexts shape he development and deployment of AI technologies, and, in turn, how emerging AI technologies transform social practices, institutions, and everyday life. Key topics include the socio-ethical issues surrounding AI systems, its entanglement with dominant political economy structures, and the ways cultural and institutional factors shape AI application, regulation, and governance. The course aims to foster critical reflection among STEM students on their research experiences and the broader societal implications of their work, while equipping humanities and social science students with foundational AI literacy necessary for engaging with a technologically evolving world.

2 Assignments and Grading

2.1 Class Participation and Attendance: 20%

Students are required to attend all classes and actively participate in discussions. I keep close track of those students who consistently and thoughtfully participate in class discussions. Participation grades will be based on attendance, preparation for class, and the quality of their participation in class discussions and interactions.

2.2 Presentation: 20%

Students will explore the creative use of AI. Further details will be provided during class.

2.3 Term Paper: 30%

Students will analyze power and knowledge production in AI systems. Further details will be provided during class.

2.4 Final Exam: 30%

The exam will be open-book and composed of short-answer or long-essay questions. Students may bring any printed or handwritten materials to the exam, but electronic devices are prohibited. The exam questions will be drawn from all course materials. It is strongly suggested that students complete all the required readings before the exam.

3 Class Policies

3.1 Late Work Policy

No late submission will be accepted and no make-up exams will be given unless the condition is (1) prearranged with and approved by the instructor or (2) the result of a documented emergency (such as a family/health emergency). Documentation is necessary in any case.

3.2 Attendance

Consistent attendance and active participation are crucial for learning the class materials and earning a good grade. Three unexcused absences will lead to a zero mark in participation.

3.3 Email Policy

Students are encouraged to use email to schedule appointments or address other administrative matters. I will strive to respond to emails in a timely manner, but due to my other professional obligations, it may not always be possible to reply promptly. Please expect a reply in 24 hours on working days. For questions about course content, please speak with me in person after class or during consultation sessions.

3.4 Unauthorized Distribution of Course Material

Students are prohibited from distributing files, photos, or screenshots from the course without prior consent of the instructor.

3.5 Academic Integrity

Attention is drawn to University policy and regulations on honesty in academic work, and to the disciplinary guidelines and procedures applicable to breaches of such policy and regulations. For each assignment, students will be required to submit a signed declaration acknowledging their awareness of these policies, regulations, guidelines, and procedures. For group projects, all group members must sign the declaration. Only the final version of the assignment should be submitted via VeriGuide. Additionally, the use of generative AI tools for completing assignments is strictly prohibited unless explicitly permitted by the instructor. Please familiarize yourself with the definition of academic dishonesty and punitive procedures detailed in the university policy on Academic Integrity: https://registry.cuhk.edu.cn/en/page/30. Violations of academic integrity are treated with the utmost seriousness and appropriate sanctions must be imposed.

3.6 Student Accessibility

If students have a disability and require academic accommodations, please request those accommodations through student accessibility services in a timely manner. Students with disabilities are encouraged to contact me privately at the beginning of the semester so we can make appropriate arrangements.

4 Grade Descriptor

A	Outstanding performance on all learning outcomes. Students independently synthesize and develop ideas in original ways, showing mastery of concepts, ideas, and contexts. They express ideas with exceptional clarity and logical reasoning. They demonstrate leadership and provide meaningful contributions to class discussion.
A-	Strong performance on all or almost all learning outcomes. Students demonstrate a strong grasp of concepts, ideas, and contexts. They express ideas with clarity and logical reasoning. They contribute significantly to group work and class activities.
B	Good performance on some learning outcomes, compensating for less satisfactory performance on others. Students demonstrate a good grasp of concepts, ideas, and contexts. They generally express ideas with some minor mistakes or errors. They participate satisfactorily in class discussion.

C	Satisfactory performance on most learning outcomes with some weaknesses. Students demonstrate an adequate grasp of most concepts, ideas, and contexts. There is substantial room for improvement in clarity and/or logical reasoning when expressing ideas. They participate minimally in class discussion.
D	Unsatisfactory performance on a number of learning outcomes. Students demonstrate only a basic understanding of concepts, ideas, and contexts. They make limited contribution to group work and class activities.
F	Failure to achieve the majority of learning outcomes, with extremely limited or no contribution to group work and class activities. There is either nil submission or completion of all or most assignments.

5 Class Schedule and Readings

All required readings will be made available through the course website. Students should do the reading, and participate in class discussions with questions, informed opinions, and perspectives with respect to the course materials. The instructor reserves the right to make changes to this syllabus.

Week	Topic	Reading	Tutorial
Jan 5	Intro	*Read the syllabus*	
Jan 12	Social Constructivism: the Making of Technology	Bender, E. M., *et al*. (2021). On the Dangers of Stochastic Parrots: Can Language Models Be Too Big? *Proceedings of the 2021 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency,* 610-623.	
Jan 19	Marxian Perspectives: Labor, Capital, and Automation	Rosenblat, A., & Stark, L. (2016). Algorithmic Labor and Information Asymmetries: A Case Study of Uber's Drivers. *International Journal of Communication*, *10*, 3758-3784.	
Jan 26	Foucauldian Perspectives: Power, Governmentality, and the Panopticon	Medina, E. (2006). Designing Freedom, Regulating a Nation: Socialist Cybernetics in Allende's Chile. *Journal of Latin American Studies*, *38*(3), 571-606.	Pre Consultation 1
Feb 2	Feminist Perspectives: Rights, Representation, and Situated Knowledge	Thompson, C. (2019, Feb 13). The Secret History of Women in Coding. *The New York Times*. https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2019/07/29/was-the-automotive-era-a-terrible-mistake	Pre Consultation 2
Chinese New Year Holiday			
Mar 2	Postcolonial Perspectives: Empire, Racialization, and Global Infrastructure	Bianchi, F., *et al*. (2023). Easily Accessible Text-to-Image Generation Amplifies Demographic Stereotypes at Large Scale. *Proceedings of the 2023 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency,* 1493-1504.	Presentation 1

Mar 9	Human–Machine Relations: Structure-Agency, Cyborgs, and Socio-Technical Systems	Haraway, D. J. (1985). A Manifesto for Cyborgs: Science, Technology, and Socialist Feminism in the 1980s. *Socialist Review, 80*, 65-108.	Presentation 2
Mar 16	AI and Politics: Warfare, Geopolitics, and Industrial Policy	Gray, J. E. (2021). The Geopolitics of 'Platforms': The TikTok Challenge. *Internet Policy Review*, *10*(2).	
Mar 23	AI and Intellectual Property: Knowledge, Commons, and Privatization	Chesterman, S. (2025). Good Models Borrow, Great Models Steal: Intellectual Property Rights and Generative AI. *Policy and Society*, *44*(1), 23-37.	
Mar 30	AI and Environment: Malthusian Limits, Cornucopian Optimism, and Sustainability	Strubell, E., Ganesh, A., & McCallum, A. (2020). Energy and Policy Considerations for Modern Deep Learning Research. *Proceedings of the AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence*, 34(9), 13865–13869.	
Apr 6	*Qingming Festival Holiday*		
Apr 13	AI and Ethics: Algorithmic Bias, Fairness, and Accountability	Mittelstadt, B. D., Allo, P., Taddeo, M., Wachter, S., & Floridi, L. (2016). The Ethics of Algorithms: Mapping the Debate. *Big Data & Society*, *3*(2), 1-21.	
Apr 20	*Final Exam*		Essay Consultation 1
Apr 27	*Essay Consultation*		Essay Consultation 2
May 4	*Labor Day Holiday*		